



● Kareena Kapoor
Rs 3.5 crore



● Priyanka Chopra
Rs 2 crore

NEHA NATH

they're worth." Even actors created by independent movies, such as Vinay Pathak and Ranvir Shorey, are now getting upwards of Rs 50 lakh. "How can the Rs 4-crore movie that created them be viable," asks Sudhir Mishra. And then answers it himself: "People are waiting to be discovered. We'll just have to do it."



BHASKAR PAUL

● Aamir Khan
Rs 20 crore

Goal and *Chocolate*, has a Rs 3.5 crore contract from Reliance.

Even the suits have benefited. Two years ago Sandeep Bhargava had quit advertising and was just one man working from his Pali Hill home on a Dell laptop. Today, as Indian Films CEO, he sits in a 5,000-sq ft office overlooking the Mahalaxmi Race Course. Five years ago, Ronnie Screwvala would wait outside the Doordarshan director-general's office for an appointment. Today, as the UTV Group CEO he can greenlight a 16th century romance between Akbar and a creatively imagined princess for Rs 33 crore and come out smelling of roses with the box-office delivering Rs 120 crore in 51 days. Two years ago, Ritesh Sidhwani was just a smart young man who made one film in two years with his Maneckji Cooper school friend Farhan Akhtar. Now their Excel Entertainment has a five-film Rs 250-crore deal with Reliance, which has enabled him to make three films a year.

Simply put, Bollywood has grown because more people are watching its films. If admissions in 2001 were 2.8 billion, in 2006, the figure went up to over 3.9 billion (compared to just 1.7 billion for the US). Similarly ticket sales too have grown, from \$593 million in 2001 to \$1.4 billion (Rs 5,600 crore) in 2006, pygmy-like when compared to the 2007 US box-office revenue of \$26.7 billion but, still significant. And the audience has grown because avenues have. Take a look. The domestic theatrical division which was just 12,000 single screens

earlier, now encompasses multiplexes (660 screens, set to grow to 1,800 by 2012-13). There is an Adlabs in Pathankot and a PVR in Latur. The number may be tiny compared to even other Asian nations—in 2004, multiplex penetration in India was just 1.6 per cent, compared to 62.5 per cent in Japan and 70 per cent in Thailand—but even the format has expanded, from print to include digital cinemas as well. Similarly overseas. Not only have the number of prints expanded but also the format, with digital screens in 50 territories now. Home video now includes VCDs and DVDs. Music now includes the physical as well as the digital format with songs being downloaded on the mobile and Internet. Television rights include satellite rights to multiple broadcasters with a cap on airings, DTH, and inflight rights. Now, movies can be extended with infilm placements and merchandising. Also there is a reduction of the time window for each format—even a successful movie such as *Jab We Met* was out on home video in less than three months.

The market has expanded geographically as well. Sidhwani for instance has just sold *Don* for €150,000 (Rs 93 lakh) to a distributor in Germany, where Shah Rukh mania is at its peak. Pakistan is slowly showing signs of releasing Indian films legitimately. UTV's *Goal* has already made \$500,000 (Rs 2 crore). *Race* had a 15-print release across nine Pakistani cities, while *Taare Zameen Par* will also have a 15 print release there. Even in traditional markets such as the UK, the scale has gone up. In 1989, Kishore Lulla of Eros released *Sanam Bewafa* in one theatre in London. Last year, he had a grand premiere of *Om Shanti Om* at West End's Empire cinema, apart from releasing it in 51 theatres in England.

With corporates insisting on electronic ticketing in even territories such as north Bihar now, greater transparency is showing real returns, which stars now have access to. Which is why all stars are either turning to co-productions or demanding a fee plus a share of the revenues. Take the example of Rajkumar Hirani's film, tentatively titled *Idiots*, which he wanted to do with Shah Rukh. The mere suggestion from the actor that he could co-produce the film